

# Types of Social Engineering

Estimated time: 10 minutes

## Objectives

After completing this reading, you will be able to:

- Explain the various types of social engineering attacks.
- List the different strategies involved in social engineering attacks.

## Social engineering types

Social engineering is a particularly deceitful tactic used by malicious individuals to coerce unsuspecting targets into revealing sensitive data. This malicious strategy works by exploiting human vulnerabilities rather than technical flaws. Let's look at the different types of social engineering and examine how each type uses deception, trust, and persuasion to breach personal and organizational security measures.

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| Phishing             | <p>Phishing is a fraudulent attempt to obtain sensitive information by masquerading as a trustworthy entity through electronic communication. Typically, attackers mass distribute emails, hoping to trick recipients into providing personal data or clicking malicious links.</p> <p>Phishing schemes are used to steal credentials. They often involve counterfeit versions of legitimate login pages designed to deceive individuals into submitting their usernames and passwords. In more sophisticated instances of these schemes, the stolen information is immediately used to access the actual site, preventing victims from realizing that their login attempt has failed.</p>                                                                        |
| Spear phishing       | <p>Spear phishing is a more targeted version of phishing where attackers tailor their approach to a specific individual or organization. It involves personalized emails that appear credible enough to deceive the target into sharing confidential information.</p>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |
| Whaling              | <p>Whaling attacks are a form of spear phishing that specifically targets high-profile individuals like CEOs or CFOs, the "big fishes" in an organization. Whalers often create highly sophisticated and executive-specific lures to acquire sensitive data or money.</p>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |
| Vishing              | <p>Vishing, or voice phishing, uses phone calls instead of emails to scam individuals. The attacker pretends to represent a legitimate institution to lure individuals into providing personal, financial, or security information.</p>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                           |
| Tailgating           | <p>Tailgating is another form of social engineering. This physical security breach occurs when an attacker exploits a moment when a controlled entry point is opened by an authorized individual.</p>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |
| Impersonation        | <p>In impersonation, an attacker adopts a false identity to deceive individuals or organizations into granting access to restricted areas or divulging sensitive information. This technique may involve posing as technical support personnel, company employees, or trusted vendors.</p>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
| Dumpster diving      | <p>Dumpster diving, though not typically categorized as a social engineering attack, is a simple but highly effective method for acquiring confidential information. This attack involves searching through an individual's or company's discarded items for valuable data. Surprisingly, waste bins can reveal a lot of insight into an organization as they contain discarded letters, notes, and reports.</p>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |
| Shoulder surfing     | <p>Shoulder surfing involves directly observing a person's private information by peering over their shoulder, a practice commonly seen when an individual is entering sensitive data, such as passwords. While this term traditionally refers to the physical act of spying, similar strategies include using reflective surfaces to view credentials.</p>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
| Hoax                 | <p>A hoax involves the distribution of false alarms or misinformation to deceive, create panic, or manipulate individuals. Typically, a hoax might incite users to install unnecessary software or perform certain actions based on the fabricated information.</p>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |
| Watering hole attack | <p>A watering hole attack operates by lying in wait at locations frequently visited by the target. Just like predators in the wild wait at watering holes for their prey, cybercriminals identify and compromise websites that are popular with their intended victims. Unlike redirection attacks that steer users to malicious websites, watering hole attacks compromise a legitimate website that the attackers know their targets are likely to visit. Once the website frequented by the targets is identified, attackers concentrate their efforts on that site. They potentially exploit vulnerabilities within the site's security or infect it through indirect methods, such as compromised ad networks, to deliver malware to unsuspecting users.</p> |

